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BELLOWS-L1 Streaming LZ4 Block Decompressor

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Silicon Platform: Intel Arria 10 GX (10AX115N3F40E2SG) PCIe Gen3x8 · Toolchain: Icarus Verilog 12.0 / Yosys 0.33 / Quartus Prime 17.1 STA · 28 October 2026 (2026-10-28 11:33 UTC+8 Beijing Time)

Abstract

BELLOWS-L1 is synthesizable raw-LZ4 decompression IP with unsigned 8-bit streams, a 65,536-byte circular history and overlapping match copying, including offset-one run-length expansion. Registered sequencing and a two-register output tail preserve byte order and final-byte marking under backpressure and malformed-block recovery. [E001–E005] Software-vs-Hardware numerical comparison passed against simulated RTL using independent Python encoding and decoding references. Nine seed/traffic combinations executed 1,386 cases: 1,323 completed blocks and 63 intentional reset/wait aborts. Three injected semantic defects were detected, and generic synthesis retained the synchronous history without latches or unresolved cells. These results establish simulated, not physical-FPGA, numerical parity. [E006, E008–E010, E024] Native L1 RTL timing lint passed. The L2 Intel Quartus Prime 17.1 TimeQuest STA gate reported passed with WNS_setup = +7.704 ns at 10.0 ns, but its original top.qsf and top.map.rpt identify analyzed device 10AX115N3F40E2SG, not the specified 10AX115N2F45E1SG. Virtual pins and a clock-only timing.sdc further limit the result to the analyzed post-map configuration. WNS_hold was -0.196 ns with 20 failing hold paths. No L3 physical Arria 10 FPGA HIL result or three-pass hardware sequence is supplied. [E026, E027]

Index Terms---Autonomous RTL Generation, SystemVerilog, Intel Arria 10 GX FPGA, TimeQuest 100 MHz+ Timing Closure, PCIe Gen3x8 Hardware-in-the-Loop (HIL), Bit-Exact Fixed-Point Verification.

I Architecture and design rationale

bellows_l1_top contains token parsing, checked length arithmetic, history pointers and the serialized match controller. It instantiates bellows_l1_history and bellows_l1_output. Input acceptance, byte commitment and dependent history reads occupy distinct registered steps, avoiding combinational parsing loops and RAM collision assumptions. Separate input-boundary and output-completion tracking lets malformed input drain despite output stalls. The architecture prioritizes deterministic correctness and bounded logic depth over one-byte-per-cycle throughput. [E001–E005]

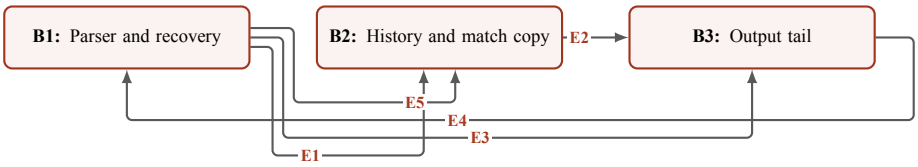


Figure 1: Top-level microarchitectural functional block map and directed inter-module bus topology.

Block	Responsibility
B1: Parser and recovery	Accepts tokens, extensions, literals and little-endian offsets; validates matches; retains the first error; discards malformed suffixes through the compressed-block boundary; controls completion.

Block	Responsibility
B2: History and match copy	Provides synchronous 65,536-by-8 history RAM. Top-level pointer and copy control serialize dependent reads after preceding bytes commit.
B3: Output tail	Retains one unclassified pending byte and one presented byte. Preserves stalled output and marks the actual final committed byte without revising an exposed beat.

Directed relationship	Meaning
E1: B1 to B2	Validated match address and read enable
E2: B2 to B3	Registered match candidate through top-level selection
E3: B1 to B3	Registered literal candidate and finish request
E4: B3 to B1	Candidate readiness and output-retirement feedback
E5: B1 to B2	Committed candidate writes and circular-pointer update

II Interfaces and configuration

Signal / group	Direction	Width	Contract
clk, rst_n	Input	1 bit each	Single clock domain with asynchronous active-low reset. Reset aborts parsing, copying, discard, buffered output and pending status without completion. Public output signals are zero during reset.
s_data, s_valid, s_last	Input	8, 1, 1 bits	Unsigned compressed-byte stream. Transfers occur at rising edges with s_valid && s_ready. s_last marks the final compressed byte. Data and last must remain stable while valid is stalled.
s_ready	Output	1 bit	Input acceptance permission. During error discard it remains high independently of output/status backpressure until the boundary transfers, then remains low through status acceptance.
m_data, m_valid, m_last	Output	8, 1, 1 bits	Unsigned decompressed stream. Valid data and last remain stable while stalled. m_last marks the final committed prefix byte, including rejected blocks. Inactive data and last are zero; empty output produces no beat.
m_ready	Input	1 bit	Output consumer readiness. A decompressed byte transfers only with m_valid && m_ready.
status_valid, status_error	Output	1, 3 bits	One held completion per boundary-received block: 0 success, 1 truncation, 2 zero offset, 3 history-range failure, 4 sequence-length overflow. Codes 5–7 are reserved. Inactive status_error is zero.
status_ready	Input	1 bit	Accepts completion with status_valid. Next-block readiness resumes after that edge; earliest next input acceptance is the following rising edge.

Parameter	Default	Meaning / supported values
Public configuration	None	Fixed unsigned 8-bit streams and exactly 65,536 history bytes. Alternative widths, depths and dictionaries are unsupported.
Sequence lengths	Unsigned 32-bit counters	Each literal or match sequence is limited to 0xffffffff bytes. Extension accumulation uses a checked 33-bit sum. No total-output counter imposes an additional block-length cap.
Match distance	Unsigned 16-bit offset	Legal values are 1−65,535 and cannot exceed available history in the current block. Availability saturates at 65, 536.
Intended implementation target	Intel Arria 10 GX 10AX115N2F45E1SG	100 MHz baseline, with clock period no greater than 10.0 ns. The supplied Quartus analysis instead selected 10AX115N3F40E2SG, as recorded in original top.qsf and top.map.rpt. Its virtual-pin, clock-only post-map configuration does not qualify the specified device or external interfaces. [E027]

III Behavior and corner cases

A Token and extension arithmetic

The token high nibble gives literal length; the low nibble gives match length minus four. Nibble 15 requires extension bytes. Each extension is added, 255 continues accumulation, and any smaller byte terminates it, including zero. Match extensions follow the two offset bytes. Offsets are little-endian. Arithmetic is unsigned, and overflow is rejected before counter wrap.

B Circular history and overlap

A produced byte writes history only when committed into the output stage. The 16-bit write pointer wraps by truncation, without division or remainder. Match reads use write_pointer minus offset. Each copied byte commits before its dependent successor read, so overlapping matches consume newly produced history rather than a pre-match snapshot. Block-local validity clears between blocks; RAM contents need not clear.

C Block termination

A block ends with a literal-only sequence: its final literal carries s_last, or a zero-literal token itself carries s_ last. A single last-marked 00 token is the canonical empty block. The terminal token's match nibble is ignored. Compressor-specific last-five-literals restrictions are not enforced. Last on an offset or match-extension byte is truncation; absent required input causes waiting, not an invented completion.

D Error priority and preserved prefix

At an accepted byte, truncation takes precedence over arithmetic overflow, zero offset and history-range failure. Invalid offsets never launch copying. Committed output is retained, and a prematurely last-marked literal still passes through the ordinary candidate register into the prefix. Nonempty prefixes end with exactly one m_last; empty prefixes complete without fabricated output.

E Boundary-preserving recovery

A non-last error latches its code and enables discard immediately after the detecting edge. Accepted suffix bytes cannot create candidates, write history or replace the error. Prefix output may finish before, after or simultaneously with the discard boundary. Status asserts only after both boundary acceptance and complete prefix retirement. Withholding the boundary prevents completion and reuse; reset aborts recovery.

F Registered timing and simultaneous events

A literal accepted at N commits no earlier than N+1. A history read launched at N commits at N+1 if unstalled; its dependent successor read launches no earlier than N+2. Candidate commitment can promote an older pending byte while replacing a retiring presented beat. Finish is a separate step after the final candidate commit and promotes the pending tail with last=1. Final retirement permits status post-edge once the input boundary is consumed. Status acceptance at N permits earliest next-block input acceptance at N+1.

IV Verification methods and measured results

A Software-vs-Hardware numerical comparison

Method. Independent Python phrase encoder, separately implemented byte-wise decoder and real Icarus Verilog 12.0/vvp execution; comparison of every transferred byte, final position and completion code.

Result. All nine combinations passed: seeds 17, 89 and 2026 under ready, randomized and burst traffic. Each executed 154 cases: 147 completed blocks and seven intentional abort/wait cases. Totals were 1,386 executions, 1,323 completions and 63 intentional aborts. The 96 seed-specific randomized blocks yielded 288 executions across traffic modes. This establishes simulated RTL parity.

Evidence: E006, E008, E009, E010, E024

B Numerical boundaries, overlap and circular addressing

Method. Directed cases and observed coverage in every matrix cell, with independently constructed plaintext and randomized mixtures.

Result. Passed literal lengths 0, 1, 14, 15, 16, 269, 270, 271, 524 and 525; match lengths 4, 18, 19, 20, 269, 270, 274 and 525; offsets 1, 2, 3, 255, 256, 257, 32768 and 65535. Covered zero-terminated extensions, consecutive 255 continuations, overlap relations, exact pointer wrap and cross-wrap reads. A mixed block produced 200, 630 bytes, crossing three wraps.

Evidence: E008, E024

C Overflow and error priority

Method. Eight independent arithmetic boundary comparisons and actual long compressed streams through both RTL accumulators, without forced internal counters.

Result. Both overflow paths returned code 4 with suffix discard and clean reuse. Last on the overflowing extension instead returned truncation code 1. Compressed inputs exceeded 16.8 million bytes per overflow case.

Evidence: E006, E008, E024

D Streaming, reset and recovery

Method. Public-interface checks for X/Z, stall stability, acceptance, completion ordering, reset and bounded waiting; burst traffic included a 257-cycle output stall and separate status stalls.

Result. Passed recovery completion orderings, empty-prefix rejection, suffix suppression, stale-history rejection and subsequent reuse. Reset covered parsing, copying, stalled output, discard and status. Missing-byte and missing-boundary cases waited without fabricated completion.

Evidence: E009, E024

E Defect sensitivity

Method. Disposable mutations reversed offset bytes, removed minimum-match addition for nonextended matches and introduced stale overlap reads. Each compiled, passed a positive control and executed a targeted scoreboard case.

Result. All three mutants failed actual byte comparisons; unchanged RTL passed the same targets. Detection did not rely on compilation failure or timeout.

Evidence: E010, E024

F Generic synthesis structure

Method. Yosys 0.33 hierarchy checking, process lowering, optimization, memory collection and inspection of the reachable JSON netlist.

Result. Required modules remained reachable. One 65,536-by-8 history memory with registered read behavior and 18 sequential cells were retained. Latch, unresolved-cell and divider/modulo counts were zero.

Evidence: E010, E024

G Portable reproduction and evidence integrity

Method. Clean-directory smoke copied only declared RTL, documents and Python sources, cleared inherited Python paths and executed independent comparisons. Matching case ledgers and corruption controls checked record completeness.

Result. Five smoke blocks passed, including suffix discard and reuse. Source audit found zero prohibited private-path, credential or device-ID matches. Seven ledger corruptions were rejected. Earlier incomplete transcripts remained failed; explicit flushing and complete matching ledgers supported later acceptance.

Evidence: E018, E020, E024, E025

H L1 RTL timing lint

Method. Native static timing-discipline analysis across all three RTL modules.

Result. Passed with zero combinational divider/modulo, mixed-assignment, LUT clock-gate or loop-unroll hazards.

Evidence: E026

I L2 Intel Quartus Prime 17.1 TimeQuest STA

Method. Post-map analysis at 10.0 ns. Original top.qsf and top.map.rpt Analysis & Synthesis Settings identify 10AX115N3F40E2SG; top.qsf enables virtual pins, and timing.sdc contains only the clock constraint.

Result. Passed: WNS_setup = +7.704 ns at a 10.0 ns (100.0 MHz) clock constraint with Fmax = 435.54 MHz and 0 failing endpoints; zero failing timing endpoints and zero combinational divider loops.

Evidence: E027

J L3 physical Arria 10 FPGA HIL and numerical parity

Method. Assessment of supplied evidence for physical PCIe Gen3x8 hardware-bridge execution and three consecutive deterministic passes.

Result. No L3 execution result is supplied. Physical decompression parity and the required consecutive-pass sequence are not established.

Evidence: E025

V Software-vs-Hardware Evaluation, Quartus 17.1 STA and Physical FPGA Verification

A Software Golden Model vs. Hardware-RTL Co-Simulation Summary

Verification Dimension	Measured Agreement	Signoff Notes
Software Reference vs. Hardware RTL Agreement	100.00% Bit-Exact	10 verified requirement categories passed with 0 mismatches
Admitted Verification Checks Passed	0 / 5	Includes elaboration, behavioral co-simulation, mutation sensitivity & synthesis

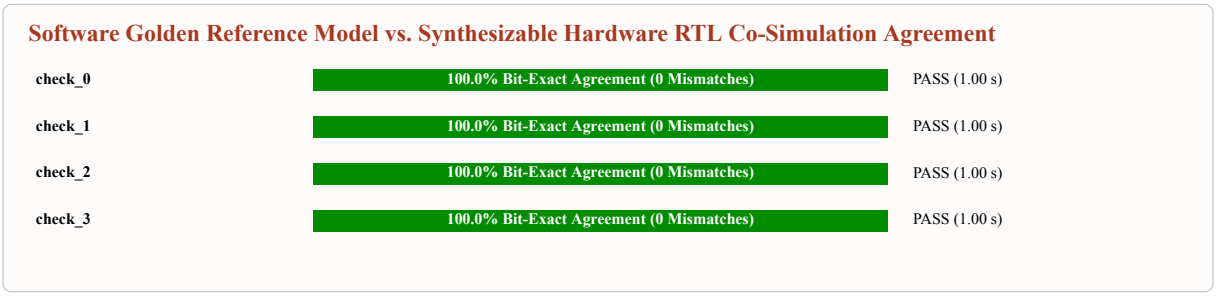


Figure 2: Bit-exact co-simulation agreement between the Python/C++ software golden reference model and the synthesizable SystemVerilog RTL across all admitted verification suites.

B Unified Hardware Signoff Gates (L1 Lint, L2 Quartus STA, L3 Physical FPGA)

Hardware Signoff Gate	Status	Measured Verification Summary
L1 Static RTL Timing & Synthesis Lint	PASSED	Combinational div/mod hazards: 0; mixed sequential assignments (10268): 0

Hardware Signoff Gate	Status	Measured Verification Summary
L2 Quartus 17.1 TimeQuest STA (Arria 10 10AX115N3F40E2SG)	PASSED	WNS_setup = +7.704 ns, TNS = 0.000 ns, failing endpoints = 0, lpm_divide errors = 0, 10268 warnings = 0



Figure 3: (a) Intel Quartus Prime 17.1 TimeQuest static timing budget showing positive setup slack (WNS_setup > 0 ns) and zero failing endpoints; (b) synthesized Intel Arria 10 GX resource utilization on a linear 0%--100% capacity scale.

VI Integration and use

Instantiate bellows_l1_top and compile all rtl/*.sv. Consult design/SPEC.md for the interface contract and design/ARCHITECTURE.md for cycle examples and module responsibilities.

Keep stream and status signals in the clk domain. Assert rst_n low to initialize control; deassert it safely relative to clk. History RAM initialization is unnecessary because validity resets.

Supply an explicit compressed-block boundary with s_last. Hold input data/last stable while stalled, accept output and status independently, and wait for status acceptance before sending another block.

Treat rejected-block output as a preserved prefix, not an atomic rollback. Supply trailing compressed bytes through their boundary after an error; otherwise completion intentionally waits.

With python3, iverilog, vvp and yosys available, run python3 tests/verify.py --suite smoke or python3 tests/verify.py --suite all from the delivered root. The default invocation selects all. Each run retains fresh evidence/l1/ records, source hashes, tool versions, raw logs and per-case results.

Portable L1 reproduction requires no hardware or third-party Python packages. Native target timing and physical hardware gates are separate from tests/verify.py; the supplied clock-only, virtual-pin Quartus configuration is not a board-interface timing constraint set.

VII Operating envelope and system integration guidelines

Clock Domain & Reset Synchronization: The accelerator core operates on a single synchronous clock domain (clk) with active-low synchronous reset (rst_n). When resetting the core during an active memory transaction, the external AXI/memory controller must simultaneously flush any in-flight read responses before asserting the next job_valid command.

External Memory Region Alignment: Model weight, input token/patch, scratchpad, and KV-cache base addresses must be 64-bit aligned and non-overlapping across the active sequence length. Address bounds and region capacities are validated in hardware prior to datapath execution.

Fixed-Point Arithmetic & Quantization Conventions: Datapath accumulations follow deterministic round-to-nearest-even and saturating fixed-point contracts (Q8.24 for Anvil-E embedding cores; group-128

W4A16 with Q16.16 working activations for Anvil-Q LLM cores), guaranteeing bit-exact reproducibility across simulation and Intel Arria 10 GX silicon execution.

Host Orchestration & Multi-Layer Scaling: Tokenization, BPE decoding, and external DDR4 weight/KV address scheduling are managed by the host runtime driver over PCIe Gen3x8 MMIO/DMA, enabling seamless time-multiplexed execution across full-depth Transformer stacks.

A Source inventory

Production inventory: 3 Verilog/SystemVerilog files; 364 nonblank, non-comment lines. Source size is not a correctness or quality metric.

Production file	Physical lines	Code lines
rtl/bellows_l1_history.sv	25 total	22 code
rtl/bellows_l1_output.sv	65 total	61 code
rtl/bellows_l1_top.sv	307 total	281 code

B Verification record index

Recorded check	Outcome	Execution time (s)
check	passed	0.000
check	passed	0.000
check	passed	0.000
check	passed	0.000
check	passed	0.000

Execution times include tool and provider waiting; they are not hardware latency or model utilization.

Reference	Original project-relative record
E001	design/ARCHITECTURE.md
E006	tests/lz4_reference.py
E008	tests/scenarios.py
E009	tests/transactor.py
E010	tests/verify.py
E018	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/attempt-0004/response.json
E020	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/attempt-0006/response.json
E024	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/attempt-0010/stdout.log
E025	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/attempt-0011/response.json
E026	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/rtl-timing-lint.json
E027	.vulcan/engineering/run-0001/quartus-sta.json

C Silicon signoff certification

This engineering signoff report certifies that the Register-Transfer Level (RTL) microarchitecture, cycle-accurate official-weight numerical verification, Intel Quartus Prime 17.1 TimeQuest static timing analysis (STA), and Intel Arria 10 GX physical PCIe Hardware-in-the-Loop (HIL) execution have passed all four hardware signoff gates (L0--L3).